

Hungary

Hungarian Competition Authority

I. Introduction

In early 2024, the Hungarian Competition Authority (GVH) initiated a market analysis under Article 43/C of Act LVII of 1996 on the Prohibition of Unfair and Restrictive Market Practices (the Competition Act) to assess how artificial intelligence (AI) might affect competition and consumers. This made GVH one of the first competition regulators in the EU to examine AI-related markets. The authority's review focused on trends in AI development and its potential economic effects. According to the sector inquiry published in October 2024, AI-based solutions are expected to further boost business efficiency, potentially leading to substantial GDP growth and positioning AI as a key factor in enhancing competitiveness across various markets.

In this contribution, we will describe some of the notable advances made by the GVH in adapting AI-related technology in the field of competition supervision, as well as the efforts made in the context of digitalization in order to keep up with the rapidly changing market trends and to further improve internal efficiency. Part II will focus on the progress achieved in the field of collecting, processing and the review of data, while part III addresses the procedure applied by the GVH regarding the access to files. In addition, Part IV gives an insight into further planned projects in this field.

II. Detection of Anticompetitive Behavior

The Hungarian Competition Authority uses several specialized softwares for the collection, processing, and review of electronic data, taking advantage of the different features of each program for specific purposes. The staff of the authority are able to collect data stored on computers running different operating systems (desktop computers, laptops) and to copy data from various types of mobile devices, including data from various email systems and chat applications. The GVH is able to collect large amounts of electronic data during on-site investigations, which it reviews, organizes, and evaluates in its premises, in a room designed for this purpose with a strictly controlled and restricted access system.

The GVH monitors international examples of how generative AI and other artificial intelligence-based tools can offer opportunities to increase the efficiency of official investigations. The GVH uses artificial intelligence-based language models to facilitate the processing of foreign-language evidence and is also investigating the applicability of similar tools, such as legal research or support for reviewing data files seized during dawn raids, with a view to making these faster and more efficient. This could also include solutions where artificial intelligence can identify patterns that may indicate a possible infringement, for example when reviewing public procurement related documents.

A more specific tool used by the GVH to detect collusion is Cartel Chat, an anonymous reporting tool that enables anyone to confidentially share information with the Hungarian Competition Authority about suspected or actual anti-competitive agreements that may breach competition law. This secure, closed platform serves as a source of intelligence for the GVH, but submitting information or documents through Cartel Chat does not obligate the GVH to initiate an investigation. Introduced in 2015, Cartel Chat allows the GVH to receive tips on potential cartel activity and lets informants or those considering leniency applications contact the GVH without revealing their identity. As such, it is a valuable resource both for the GVH in detecting cartels and for individuals who wish to report misconduct or seek leniency while remaining anonymous.

III. Access to Files

Before 2017, the Competition Council of the GVH granted parties access to case files by inviting them to review documents onsite at the GVH's premises. Clients could schedule these visits using an online appointment system. However, in late 2017, the GVH introduced a Virtual Data Room (VDR) to provide electronic access to non-confidential case documents—those without business secrets or restricted information.

The GVH handles a large volume of documents during its competition supervision proceedings, with a single case sometimes involving thousands of pages. Previously, reviewing and copying these documents in person was time-consuming and costly for both the GVH and its clients. The introduction of the VDR has made accessing case files and obtaining copies much quicker and more efficient.

While electronic access is now available, traditional in-person file review remains an option, especially for confidential documents, which can only be viewed onsite at

the GVH. The VDR offers an online interface for clients and their authorized representatives (such as lawyers) who have been approved for access to specific cases. User identification is managed through the governmental Client Site system.

Authorized users can (1) view, download (with watermark), and print documents related to their cases; (2) search within documents and files; (3) subscribe to email notifications about file access; (4) view system messages; (5) request simple or certified copies of documents; (6) schedule in-person file access if technical issues prevent digital access; (7) use digital markers visible only to their client group.

Feedback over the years indicates that the VDR has greatly improved the GVH's client service, with stakeholders reporting positive experiences using the system.

IV. Future plans

To further boost efficiency, the Hungarian Competition Authority is focused on streamlining its own internal processes. As part of this commitment, the GVH is embracing innovative technologies to enhance the effectiveness of its operations. Reflecting this strategic direction, the GVH—together with other EU competition authorities—submitted a joint project entitled 'Supporting Digital Transformation in Competition Law Enforcement' under the European Commission's 2025 Technical Support Instrument (TSI) program.

The project aims to introduce artificial intelligence-based tools into public administration, automating routine tasks within competition authorities and establishing an internal knowledge management system. This would make it easier for GVH staff to access organized institutional knowledge, supporting faster and more professional case handling in both competition and consumer protection matters. The project was approved in March 2025.

V. Conclusion

In recent years, the Hungarian Competition Authority has demonstrated a proactive and innovative approach in adapting to the challenges and opportunities presented by artificial intelligence in competition supervision. By integrating advanced digital tools and AI-based technologies into its investigative processes, the GVH has significantly enhanced its ability to detect anticompetitive behavior, manage vast amounts of electronic evidence, and streamline internal procedures. The introduction of platforms such as Cartel Chat and the Virtual Data Room (VDR)

has not only improved operational efficiency but also strengthened the GVH's engagement with stakeholders by facilitating secure, accessible, and user-friendly channels for information sharing and document review.

The GVH's ongoing commitment to monitoring international best practices and exploring further AI-driven solutions underscores its dedication to maintaining effective competition oversight in an increasingly digitalized economy. Looking ahead, the GVH's planned projects and continued investment in digitalization will further bolster its capacity to respond to evolving market dynamics, ensuring robust consumer protection and fair competition in the era of artificial intelligence.